

companies seem to be a huge increase in security risk. Have all my data, my processes, my applications and put it out there in the big wide world, it strikes me as crazy, what is your opinion on this?

K: If there is some expensive application which you don't need regularly, just rent it. It will work. e.g., taxation software once a year. Last year there was a very curious story, a Microsoft patch upgrade which had a bug and which stopped financial taxation software in Germany. And that happened just before April 1st, the last day of taxation, and after that there is penalty. The most popular software stopped working and that was a very, very big scandal in Germany. There were many complaints about Microsoft. Some services will be online and some will be end point.

EH: One service that has to be online is regular updates. Now, is that not a vulnerability in itself?

K: Actually this service is not; I don't want to call it online, because you download anyway, so it's stored locally. You send some data there and they report to you if it's dangerous or not. So the decision maker is offline. Not offline is remote. And about the updates, if they are a risk or not, there was an incident with some anti-malware product when there was a fake update and there was a serious problem with a company which infected computers through the update.

EH: The risk is always there. If you step out of your front door, you are always at risk.

K: Especially if you do it regularly!

K: I read that your mobile security now incorporates functionality to wipe the phone if it's stolen or something like that. Now, does that not include some risk of you know if I am using my phone and suddenly it goes wrong and it gets wiped?

K: There is a password which you can set yourself so you can use it as complicated a password as you like and if you use a secure password it's very unlikely that someone will ... it will take like 1 billion SMS messages to brute-force the password. That's impossible.

EH: You mentioned in your response there the use of a password as an authentication device. It's getting increasingly difficult for people out there even to know what a strong password is and then to remember them; you know you have your bank, banks now want two passwords, one for logging in and one for

I use MS Windows XP SP3. I even use Internet Explorer, but I have a special configuration for security, so I am safe

transactions you make. You may have two banks, a credit card, it's getting increasingly difficult for people to manage it without writing the wretched thing down, which I think is the biggest security risk you can make with a password. Do you have any particular advice on password management?

K: What I do, the numbers, like pin codes, it's hidden somewhere in my address book of my mobile phone. So it's just some contact; it's built in and it's quite secure, I mean if it's stolen or lost they can't recognize which contact is real and which is not and where these digits are located. That's secure ... I think that's secure. So they have to steal at the same time, mobile phone and your card. But in this case you can call bank to ask someone to help you.

For the passwords, make it in such a way: if something really important has happened in my life especially if I need to create a new password; I'd like to add some name of a place or name of a person which I will remember for sure; some digits like the date it happened but put in a different position. It's easy to remember, so even if the password is lost, you forgot it, just remember the place you were the moment you developed the password and in which way you use digits and other letters. It's easy to remember.

EH: Unfortunately, regarding these methods, many banks are now using a virtual keyboard which only allows lower case and only allows numerals, this is introducing restriction and forcing passwords to be less entropic.

K: What the malware does; it makes a snapshot of the screen.

EH: So you like to have a long password, that has meaning to you?

K: At least 10 to 12 letter/digits. Then also I have another way for the non-Latin alphabets; in India do you have two alphabets? Latin one and Indian. So just hear some phrase in Indian and type it on the keyboard. Probably one of the best ways to write passwords is to type a sentence which is not English, using the second alphabet, but having the keyboard switched to English. It will be a mess. It will be a very, very strange combination of letters and digits. For example, if I type my name (*types on keyboard*) it will be (*more typing*) — I'm just typing my name in Cyrillic, and switch the keyboard. It's easy to remember but this is a mess. And the best way to protect your credit card or to protect your computer — just have a sticker with the wrong password on it. Or write a wrong number on your credit card. Let them try. ■